

PESTEL Analysis

Aguilar (1967); Johnson et al. (2020)

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PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A structured scan of six macro-environmental domains — political, economic, social, technological, environmental and legal — used to test whether external conditions support or threaten a venture.

WHY IT MATTERS

Tests macro-environmental feasibility across political, economic, social, technological, environmental and legal forces.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Six columns, minimum two evidenced factors each, every factor cited and dated. Close with a ranked list of the three forces that most affect the venture — an unranked PESTEL scores as descriptive, not analytical.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Political & economic forces set the operating baseline
- Social & technological forces shape demand
- Environmental & legal forces set hard constraints
- Close with the three forces that most affect the venture

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Purpose & Objectives

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Aguilar, F.J. (1967) Scanning the business environment. New York: Macmillan.

Porter's Five Forces

Porter (1980, 2008)

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PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

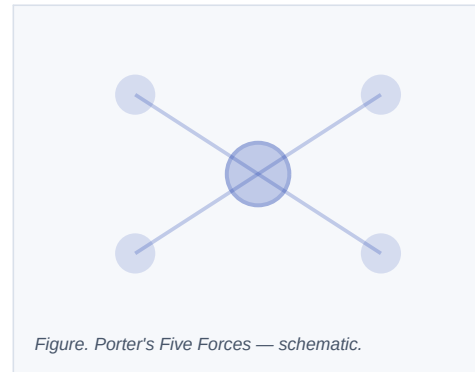
A structural model of the five competitive forces — rivalry, new entrants, substitutes, buyer power and supplier power — that jointly determine the profit potential of an industry.

WHY IT MATTERS

Establishes structural industry attractiveness and where margin will be competed away.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Rate each force high/medium/low with evidence, then state the implication for pricing power. Define the industry boundary explicitly before applying the model.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ Rivalry among existing competitors

■ Threat of new entrants and substitutes

■ Bargaining power of buyers and suppliers

■ Verdict: where margin will be competed away

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Purpose & Objectives

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Porter, M.E. (2008) 'The five competitive forces that shape strategy', Harvard Business Review, 86(1), pp. 78–93.

SWOT Analysis

Learned et al. (1969)

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PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

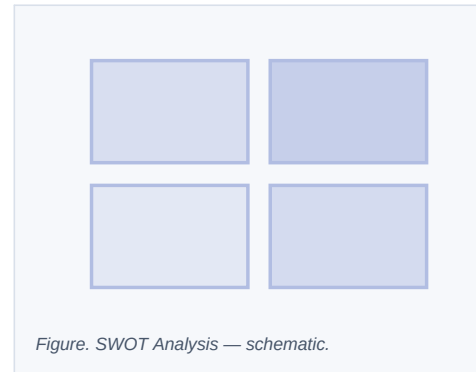
A four-quadrant consolidation of internal strengths and weaknesses against external opportunities and threats, forming the bridge between analysis and strategy.

WHY IT MATTERS

Consolidates internal capability against external conditions before strategy is formulated.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Strengths and weaknesses must be internal and controllable; opportunities and threats external. Every cell must trace to a PESTEL, Five Forces or capability finding — no free-standing assertions.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Strengths & weaknesses are internal and controllable
- Opportunities & threats are external
- Every cell traces to prior evidence
- Feeds directly into the TOWS matrix

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Purpose & Objectives

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Learned, E.P., Christensen, C.R., Andrews, K.R. and Guth, W.D. (1969) Business policy: text and cases. Homewood, IL: Richard D. Irwin.

TOWS Matrix

Wehrich (1982)

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PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

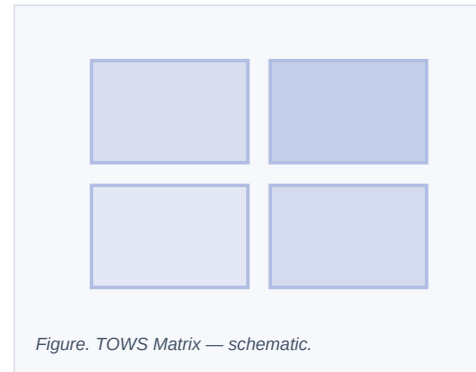
A strategy-generation matrix that pairs SWOT factors into four families of action — SO, WO, ST and WT — converting a static audit into concrete strategic options.

WHY IT MATTERS

Converts a static SWOT into four families of actionable strategy (SO, WO, ST, WT).

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Populate all four quadrants, then carry the selected strategies forward verbatim into the marketing and operations sections. TOWS is the hinge of the analytical chain.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ SO — use strengths to seize opportunities

■ WO — fix weaknesses to seize opportunities

■ ST — use strengths to counter threats

■ WT — defensive moves under weakness and threat

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Purpose & Objectives

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Wehrich, H. (1982) 'The TOWS matrix — a tool for situational analysis', Long Range Planning, 15(2), pp. 54–66.

Value Proposition Canvas

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Osterwalder et al. (2014)

PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

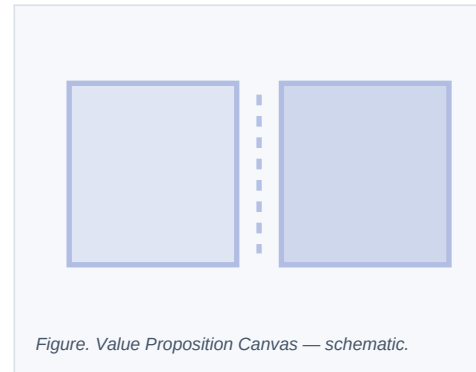
A two-sided canvas that tests fit between customer jobs, pains and gains and the product's pain relievers and gain creators before build.

WHY IT MATTERS

Proves fit between customer jobs, pains and gains and the product's pain relievers and gain creators.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Complete the customer profile from primary or secondary evidence before drafting the value map. Fit is claimed only where a specific reliever answers a specific evidenced pain.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ Customer profile: jobs, pains, gains

■ Value map: products, pain relievers, gain creators

■ Fit is claimed only where reliever answers evidenced pain

■ Built from evidence, not assumption

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Product / Service Concept

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Osterwalder, A., Pigneur, Y., Bernarda, G. and Smith, A. (2014) Value proposition design: how to create products and services customers want. Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons.

Jobs to Be Done

Christensen et al. (2016)

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PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

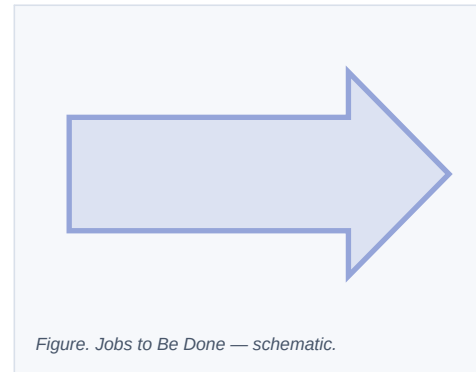
A demand-framing lens that defines the market around the progress a customer is trying to make, rather than around demographics or product categories.

WHY IT MATTERS

Frames demand around the progress the customer is trying to make rather than around demographics.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Write the job statement in the form 'when [situation], I want to [motivation], so I can [outcome]'. Identify functional, social and emotional dimensions.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ 'When [situation], I want to [motivation]...'

■ Functional, social and emotional dimensions

■ Competition is anything that does the job

■ Reveals non-obvious substitutes

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Product / Service Concept

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Christensen, C.M., Hall, T., Dillon, K. and Duncan, D.S. (2016) Competing against luck: the story of innovation and customer choice. New York: HarperBusiness.

TAM / SAM / SOM

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Blank & Dorf (2012)

PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A three-layer market-sizing model — Total, Serviceable and Obtainable market — that disciplines revenue claims and prevents top-down inflation.

WHY IT MATTERS

Sizes the market in three defensible layers and prevents inflated revenue claims.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Build bottom-up from unit price × reachable customers, cite every input, and state the SOM capture assumption as a percentage with a justification.



Figure. TAM / SAM / SOM — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

■ TAM — the whole theoretical market

■ SAM — the segment the model can serve

■ SOM — the share realistically obtainable

■ Built bottom-up, every input cited

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Market & Target Customer

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Blank, S. and Dorf, B. (2012) The startup owner's manual: the step-by-step guide for building a great company. Pescadero, CA: K&S; Ranch.

STP — Segmentation, Targeting, Positioning

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Kotler & Keller (2016)

PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

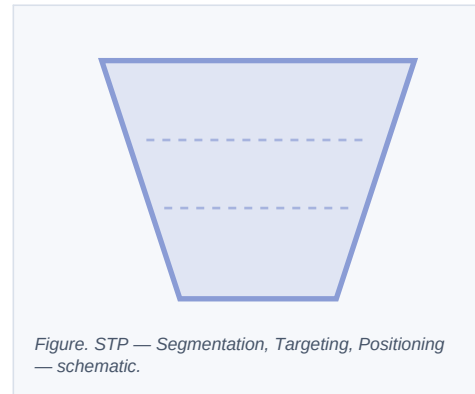
A three-step marketing logic — Segmentation, Targeting, Positioning — that selects and defends the served segment before any spend is modelled.

WHY IT MATTERS

Selects and defends the served segment before any marketing spend is modelled.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Segment on more than one variable, score segments against explicit attractiveness criteria, and finish with a one-sentence positioning statement.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ Segment on more than one variable

■ Score segments on attractiveness criteria

■ Target the defensible segment

■ Finish with a one-sentence positioning claim

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Market & Target Customer

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Kotler, P. and Keller, K.L. (2016) Marketing management. 15th edn. Harlow: Pearson.

SMART Objectives

Doran (1981)

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PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

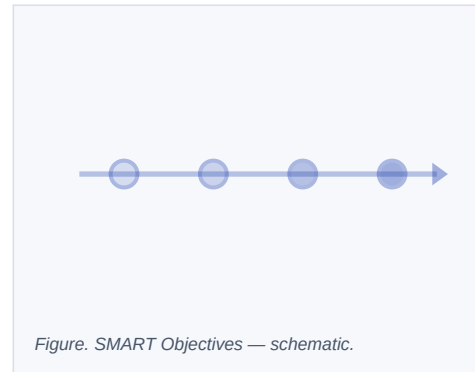
A specification standard requiring every objective to be Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant and Time-bound so the rubric can assess it.

WHY IT MATTERS

Converts intent into measurable commitments that the rubric can assess.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Each objective states a metric, a baseline, a target value and a dated deadline. 'Increase brand awareness' is not SMART; 'raise aided awareness in the Munich segment from 4% to 12% by 31/12/2027' is.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Each objective names a metric and baseline
- A target value and a dated deadline
- 'Increase awareness' is not SMART
- A measurable target is SMART

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Objectives

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Doran, G.T. (1981) 'There's a S.M.A.R.T. way to write management's goals and objectives', Management Review, 70(11), pp. 35–36.

Balanced Scorecard

Kaplan & Norton (1996)

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PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

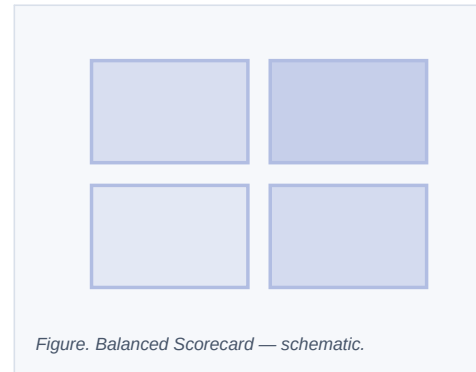
A performance framework that balances financial objectives against customer, internal-process and learning-and-growth perspectives.

WHY IT MATTERS

Balances financial objectives against customer, internal-process and learning perspectives.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

One to two objectives per perspective, each with a lead and a lag indicator. Prevents a proposal that measures only revenue.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Four perspectives, not finance alone
- One or two objectives per perspective
- Each with a lead and a lag indicator
- Prevents a revenue-only proposal

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Objectives

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Kaplan, R.S. and Norton, D.P. (1996) The balanced scorecard: translating strategy into action. Boston, MA: Harvard Business School Press.

OKR

Doerr (2018)

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PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A goal-cascade method pairing a small number of qualitative Objectives with three to five quantitative Key Results per quarter.

WHY IT MATTERS

Cascades a small number of qualitative objectives into quantitative key results by quarter.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Three to five key results per objective, each numeric. Use as the quarterly operating layer beneath the SMART annual objectives.



Figure. OKR — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Objectives are qualitative and directional
- Key Results are numeric and time-boxed
- 3–5 key results per objective
- Quarterly layer beneath annual SMART goals

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Objectives

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Doerr, J. (2018) Measure what matters: OKRs — the simple idea that drives 10x growth. London: Portfolio Penguin.

Business Model Canvas

Osterwalder & Pigneur (2010)

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PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A nine-block canvas that renders the entire venture logic on a single page and exposes hidden dependencies between the blocks.

WHY IT MATTERS

Shows the whole venture logic on one page and exposes hidden dependencies between blocks.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Complete all nine blocks, then trace the revenue line backwards to the block it depends on. Where one block carries the entire model, say so explicitly.

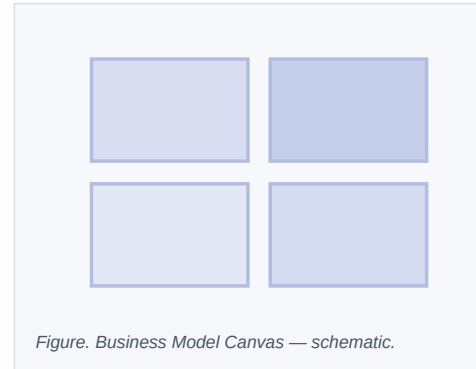


Figure. Business Model Canvas — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Nine blocks from partners to cost structure
- Revenue and cost sides must balance
- Trace revenue back to the block it depends on
- Names the single point of fragility

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Concept

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Osterwalder, A. and Pigneur, Y. (2010) Business model generation: a handbook for visionaries, game changers, and challengers. Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons.

Lean Startup / MVP

Ries (2011); Blank (2013)

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PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

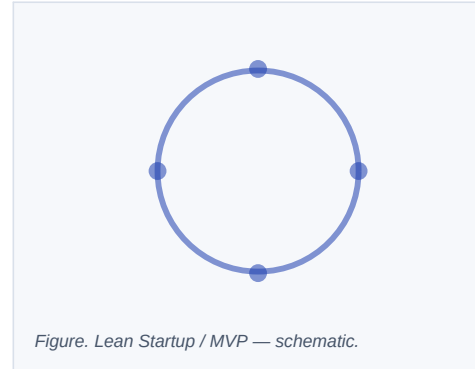
A hypothesis-driven approach that frames the venture as testable assumptions validated through build–measure–learn cycles and a minimum viable product.

WHY IT MATTERS

Frames the venture as a set of testable hypotheses rather than a fixed forecast.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

State the riskiest assumption, the experiment that would falsify it, and the success threshold. Report any validation already completed.



KEY COMPONENTS

- State the riskiest assumption first
- Design the experiment that would falsify it
- Set the success threshold in advance
- Report any validation already completed

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Concept

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Ries, E. (2011) The lean startup: how constant innovation creates radically successful businesses. London: Portfolio Penguin.

Gantt Chart

Gantt (1919)

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PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A horizontal bar schedule showing the start, duration and dependencies of every project phase against the delivery deadline.

WHY IT MATTERS

Mandatory in the EUBS proposal form: demonstrates the plan can be delivered by the deadline.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Show start and end dates for every phase, mark promoter meetings and submission gates as milestones, and identify the critical path.

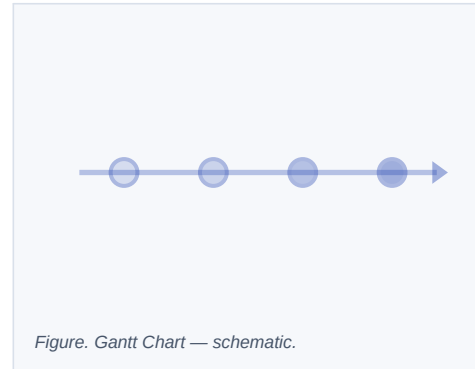


Figure. Gantt Chart — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Start and end dates for every phase
- Promoter meetings and gates as milestones
- The critical path identified
- Mandatory in the EUBS proposal form

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Timeline

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Gantt, H.L. (1919) Organizing for work. New York: Harcourt, Brace and Howe.

Risk Register (ISO 31000)

ISO (2018)

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PART I · PROPOSAL

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A risk-management register scoring each threat by likelihood and impact, with an owner, mitigation and trigger for every entry above threshold.

WHY IT MATTERS

Records what could derail delivery and what the response will be.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Score likelihood × impact on a 1–5 scale, then state owner, mitigation and trigger for each risk above threshold.



Figure. Risk Register (ISO 31000) — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Likelihood × impact on a 1–5 scale
- Owner and mitigation per risk
- Trigger conditions defined
- Aligned to the ISO 31000 process

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Timeline

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

International Organization for Standardization (2018) ISO 31000:2018 risk management — guidelines. Geneva: ISO.

Harvard Referencing

EU Business School (2026)

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The EUBS author–date citation standard; a graded component requiring a minimum of ten in-text citations audited in both directions.

WHY IT MATTERS

Graded component. A minimum of ten in-text citations is required in the proposal form.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Author–date in text, full alphabetical reference list. Every in-text citation appears in the list and every list entry appears in the body — audit in both directions.

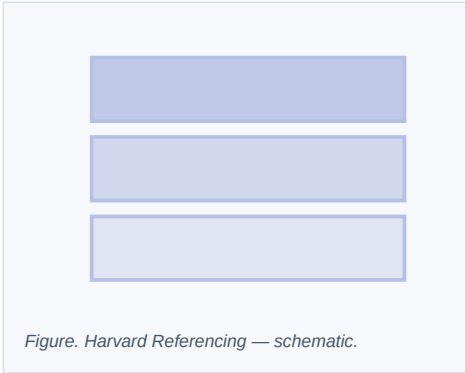


Figure. Harvard Referencing — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Author–date in text, full list at the end
- Every citation appears in the list
- Every list entry appears in the body
- Seminal originators, not secondary summaries

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part I · Proposal · Academic Standards

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

EU Business School (2026) Capstone style guide AY2026–2027. Munich: EU Business School.

Pyramid Principle

Minto (2009)

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PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A top-down communication structure that states the governing answer first, then supporting arguments, then evidence, so a two-page reader still understands the venture.

WHY IT MATTERS

Structures the summary answer-first so a reader who reads only two pages still understands the venture.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Governing thought first, then three to five supporting arguments, then evidence. Groups must be mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive.

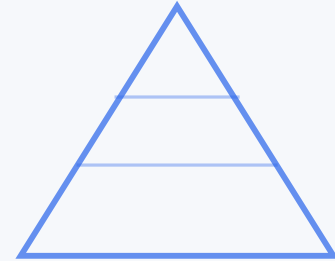


Figure. Pyramid Principle — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Governing thought stated first
- Three to five supporting arguments
- Groups mutually exclusive, collectively exhaustive
- Evidence sits at the base

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Executive Summary

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Minto, B. (2009) The pyramid principle: logic in writing and thinking. 3rd edn. Harlow: Financial Times Prentice Hall.

Golden Circle

Sinek (2009)

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PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

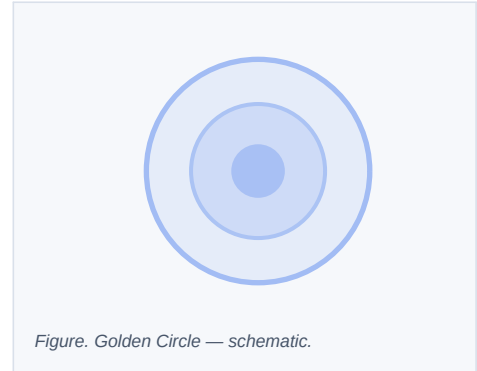
A concentric model — Why, then How, then What — that articulates organisational purpose before product and anchors the 'reasons why' section.

WHY IT MATTERS

Articulates purpose before product and gives the 'reasons why' section an analytical spine.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Why, then how, then what. Keep the why free of financial motive — that belongs in the finance chapter.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Why — the purpose and belief
- How — the distinctive approach
- What — the product or service
- Keep financial motive out of the why

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Business Identity

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Sinek, S. (2009) Start with why: how great leaders inspire everyone to take action. London: Portfolio Penguin.

Vision, Mission & Core Values

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Collins & Porras (1996)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The three foundational statements — vision, mission and core values — that describe the purpose and behavioural constraints of the business.

WHY IT MATTERS

Rubric-named requirement under Business Identity: the business statements must describe the purpose of the business.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Vision is the future state, mission the present function, values the behavioural constraints. Each value needs one sentence on how it is enforced.

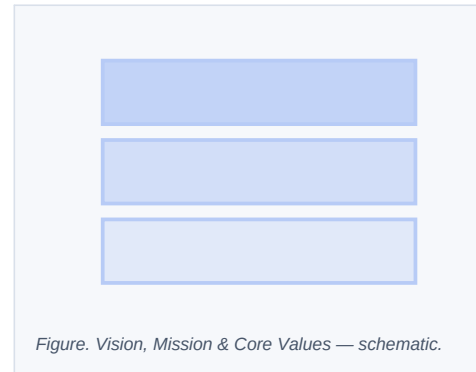


Figure. Vision, Mission & Core Values — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

■ Vision — the future state pursued

■ Mission — the present function served

■ Values — the behavioural constraints

■ Each value paired with how it is enforced

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Business Identity

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Collins, J.C. and Porras, J.I. (1996) 'Building your company's vision', Harvard Business Review, 74(5), pp. 65–77.

VRIO Framework

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Barney (1991)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

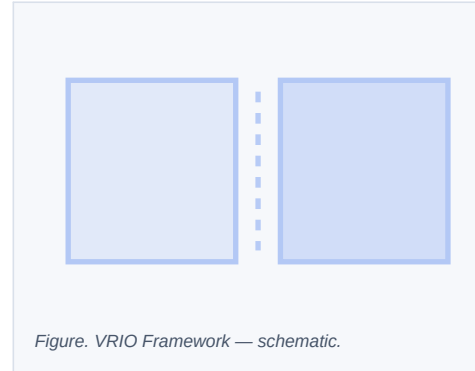
A four-test screen — Value, Rarity, Imitability, Organisation — that determines whether a resource yields sustained rather than temporary advantage.

WHY IT MATTERS

Tests whether a claimed advantage is genuinely defensible or merely a temporary edge.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Assess each resource for value, rarity, imitability and organisational support. Only resources passing all four support a sustained-advantage claim.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Valuable and Rare to give an edge
- Costly to Imitate to keep it
- Organised to capture it
- Only all four support a durable claim

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Business Identity

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Barney, J.B. (1991) 'Firm resources and sustained competitive advantage', Journal of Management, 17(1), pp. 99–120.

Generic Competitive Strategies

Porter (1985)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

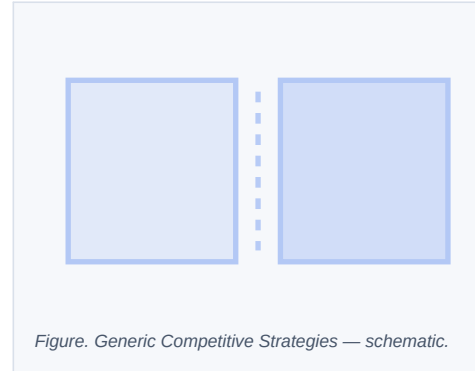
Porter's choice of three mutually exclusive strategic positions — cost leadership, differentiation or focus — that a venture must pick and evidence.

WHY IT MATTERS

Forces an explicit choice between cost leadership, differentiation and focus.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Name the chosen strategy and show the cost structure or the differentiation driver that supports it. A plan claiming both without a focus scope is 'stuck in the middle'.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ Cost leadership — lowest delivered cost

■ Differentiation — a valued distinctiveness

■ Focus — a narrow, defended scope

■ Claiming all without focus is 'stuck in the middle'

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Business Identity

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Porter, M.E. (1985) Competitive advantage: creating and sustaining superior performance. New York: Free Press.

Ansoff Growth Matrix

Ansoff (1957)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A growth-direction matrix positioning ambition across market penetration, market development, product development and diversification.

WHY IT MATTERS

Positions growth ambition across market penetration, development, product development and diversification.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Place years one to five on the matrix and show which cell each revenue stream occupies. Diversification requires the highest evidential burden.

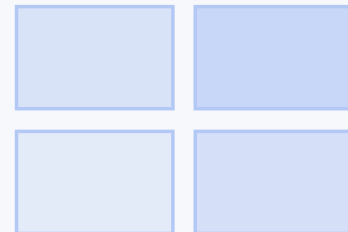


Figure. Ansoff Growth Matrix — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Penetration — existing product, existing market
- Development — new market or new product
- Diversification — new product and new market
- Diversification carries the highest evidence burden

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Business Identity

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Ansoff, H.I. (1957) 'Strategies for diversification', Harvard Business Review, 35(5), pp. 113–124.

Blue Ocean / Strategy Canvas

Kim & Mauborgne (2005)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

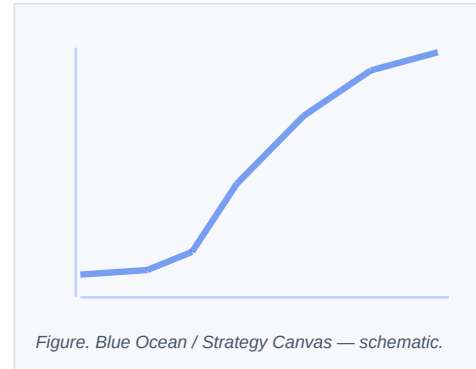
A value-curve tool that plots the venture against incumbents across competing factors to make uncontested market space visible.

WHY IT MATTERS

Plots the venture's value curve against incumbents to make differentiation visible.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Choose six to ten competing factors, plot the venture and at least two named competitors, then apply eliminate–reduce–raise–create.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Six to ten competing factors on one axis
- Venture and named rivals plotted as curves
- Eliminate–Reduce–Raise–Create applied
- Divergence is the source of the blue ocean

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Business Identity

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Kim, W.C. and Mauborgne, R. (2005) Blue ocean strategy: how to create uncontested market space and make the competition irrelevant. Boston, MA: Harvard Business School Press.

Competitor Analysis Framework

Porter (1980, ch. 3)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

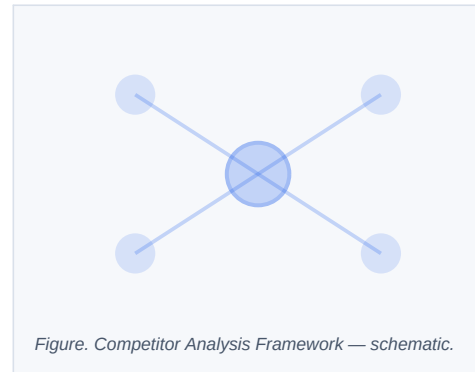
Porter's original four-component diagnostic — goals, assumptions, current strategy and capabilities — that predicts how a named rival will actually behave.

WHY IT MATTERS

The original four-component diagnostic: it predicts what a named rival will actually do, rather than merely listing who exists.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

For each major competitor establish (1) future goals, (2) current strategy, (3) assumptions held about itself and the industry, and (4) capabilities. Combine the four into a response profile answering two questions: where is this rival vulnerable, and what will provoke retaliation? A table of logos and revenue figures is not competitor analysis.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ Future goals and driving assumptions

■ Current strategy in practice

■ Capabilities and blind spots

■ Response profile: where is the rival vulnerable?

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Business Identity

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Porter, M.E. (1980) 'A framework for competitor analysis', in *Competitive strategy: techniques for analyzing industries and competitors*. New York: Free Press, pp. 47–74.

Strategic Group Mapping

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Hunt (1972); Porter (1980)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

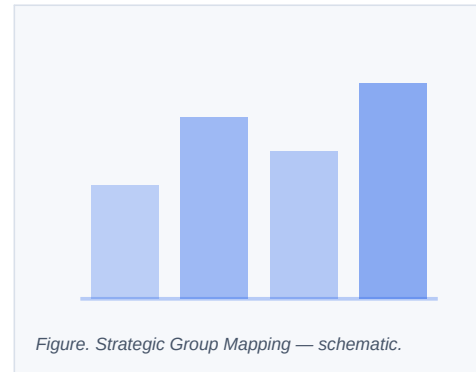
A two-dimensional map clustering rivals into strategic groups, distinguishing direct from indirect competitors and revealing mobility barriers.

WHY IT MATTERS

Distinguishes direct rivals from indirect ones and shows which cluster the venture is entering.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Choose two strategic dimensions that genuinely separate competitive approaches — never price against quality, which correlate. Plot named firms as bubbles scaled by revenue or share, mark the venture, and identify the mobility barriers protecting each group. The most serious threat usually sits in the adjacent group, not the same one.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Two dimensions that truly separate approaches
- Firms plotted as scaled bubbles
- Mobility barriers between groups
- The real threat often sits in the adjacent group

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Business Identity

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Hunt, M.S. (1972) Competition in the major home appliance industry, 1960–1970. Unpublished doctoral dissertation. Harvard University.

Competitive Profile Matrix

David & David (2017)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

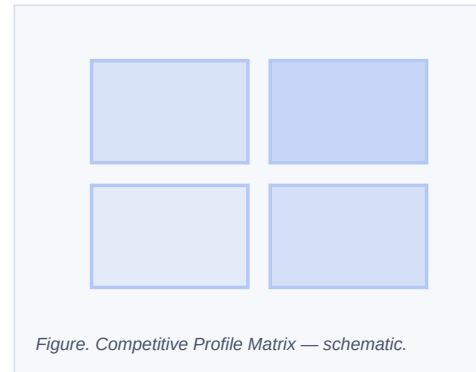
A weighted scoring matrix rating the venture against named rivals on critical success factors, converting qualitative comparison into a defensible number.

WHY IT MATTERS

Scores the venture against named rivals on weighted critical success factors, converting qualitative comparison into a defensible number.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Six to ten critical success factors, weights summing to 1.00, ratings from 1 to 4, weighted scores totalled per firm. Weights must be justified from the Five Forces and customer evidence, not assigned intuitively. State the source of every rating.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ Six to ten weighted success factors

■ Weights sum to 1.00, justified from evidence

■ Ratings 1–4 per firm

■ Weighted scores totalled and compared

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Business Identity

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

David, F.R. and David, F.R. (2017) Strategic management: a competitive advantage approach, concepts and cases. 16th edn. Harlow: Pearson.

Benchmarking

Camp (1989)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A comparison discipline that grounds cost and operational assumptions in the measured performance of comparable firms.

WHY IT MATTERS

Grounds operational and cost assumptions in what comparable firms actually achieve rather than in the founder's optimism.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Identify the process to benchmark, select comparators inside and outside the industry, measure the performance gap, and state the gap explicitly. Every industry-average figure used in the financial model should be traceable to a named benchmark source.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Select the process to benchmark
- Choose comparators in and out of industry
- Measure and state the performance gap
- Every industry average traced to a source

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Operations Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Camp, R.C. (1989) Benchmarking: the search for industry best practices that lead to superior performance. Milwaukee, WI: ASQC Quality Press.

Perceptual Mapping

Fleisher & Bensoussan (2015)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

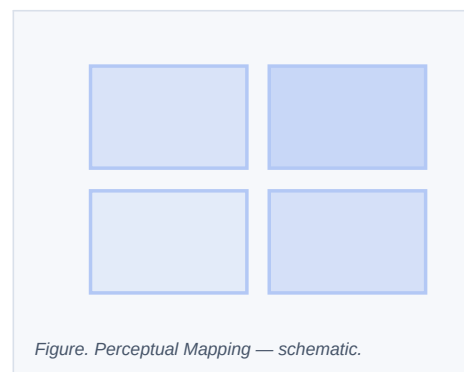
A positioning map placing the venture and named competitors on the two attributes customers actually use to choose.

WHY IT MATTERS

Shows where the venture sits in the customer's mind relative to named competitors on the attributes customers actually use to choose.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Axes must be customer-chosen attributes evidenced from research, not internal assumptions. Plot competitors from evidence and the venture from its positioning statement, then identify the unoccupied space and explain why it is unoccupied — empty quadrants are often empty for a reason.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ Axes are customer-chosen, evidenced attributes

■ Competitors plotted from evidence

■ Venture plotted from its positioning claim

■ Empty space explained, not just noted

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Marketing Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Fleisher, C.S. and Bensoussan, B.E. (2015) Business and competitive analysis: effective application of new and classic methods. 2nd edn. Upper Saddle River, NJ: Pearson FT Press.

Marketing Mix — 4Ps / 7Ps

SHEET 29 / 63

McCarthy (1960); Booms & Bitner (1981)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The controllable marketing levers — Product, Price, Place, Promotion, extended to People, Process and Physical evidence for services.

WHY IT MATTERS

Translates the chosen strategy into executable decisions; 7Ps applies to service ventures.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Each P must follow from the positioning statement. Price must reconcile to the finance chapter and place to the operations chapter — inconsistency here is a common rubric failure.



Figure. Marketing Mix — 4Ps / 7Ps — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Each P follows from the positioning claim
- Price reconciles to the finance chapter
- Place reconciles to operations
- 7Ps applies to service ventures

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Marketing Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Booms, B.H. and Bitner, M.J. (1981) 'Marketing strategies and organization structures for service firms', in Donnelly, J.H. and George, W.R. (eds.) Marketing of services. Chicago: American Marketing Association, pp. 47–51.

Positioning Statement

Ries & Trout (2001)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

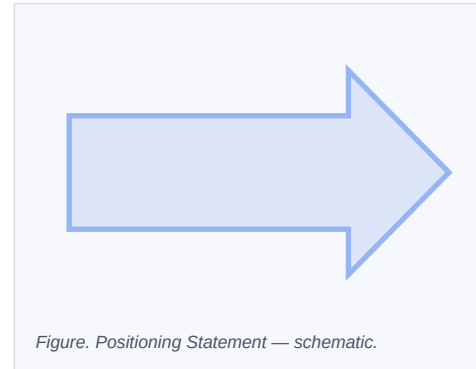
A single-sentence formula that fixes the one idea the venture will own in the customer's mind.

WHY IT MATTERS

Fixes the single idea the venture will own in the customer's mind.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

'For [segment] who [need], [brand] is the [category] that [benefit], because [reason to believe].' One sentence, one idea.



KEY COMPONENTS

- 'For [segment] who [need]...'
- '[brand] is the [category] that [benefit]...'
- '...because [reason to believe].'
- One sentence, one idea

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Marketing Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Ries, A. and Trout, J. (2001) Positioning: the battle for your mind. 20th anniversary edn. New York: McGraw-Hill.

Customer Journey Mapping

Lemon & Verhoef (2016)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

An end-to-end map of pre-purchase, purchase and post-purchase touchpoints that locates where experience is won or lost.

WHY IT MATTERS

Maps pre-purchase, purchase and post-purchase touchpoints and identifies where experience is won or lost.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Identify the touchpoint owner and the measurement for each stage. Link the map to the CX metrics in the KPI table.



Figure. Customer Journey Mapping — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

■ Stages from awareness to advocacy

■ Owner and measure per touchpoint

■ Pain points and moments of truth marked

■ Linked to CX metrics in the KPI table

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Marketing Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Lemon, K.N. and Verhoef, P.C. (2016) 'Understanding customer experience throughout the customer journey', *Journal of Marketing*, 80(6), pp. 69–96.

AIDA Funnel

Lewis (1908)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

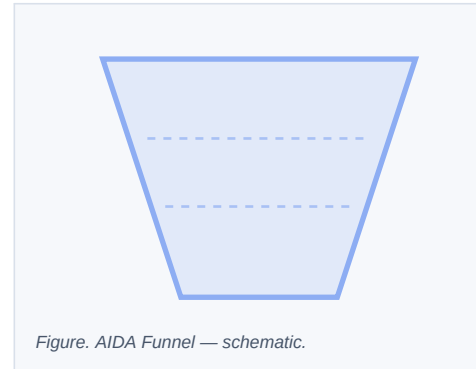
A hierarchy-of-effects funnel — Attention, Interest, Desire, Action — used to plan communication stage by stage.

WHY IT MATTERS

Legacy but rubric-friendly hierarchy of effects for communication planning.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Assign a channel, a budget line and a conversion assumption to each stage. Conversion rates must reconcile to the revenue model.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ Attention → Interest → Desire
→ Action

■ A channel and budget line per
stage

■ Conversion assumptions stated

■ Rates reconcile to the revenue
model

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Marketing Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Lewis, E.St.E. (1908) Financial advertising. Indianapolis: Levey Bros.

AARRR Pirate Metrics

SHEET 33 / 63

McClure (2007)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

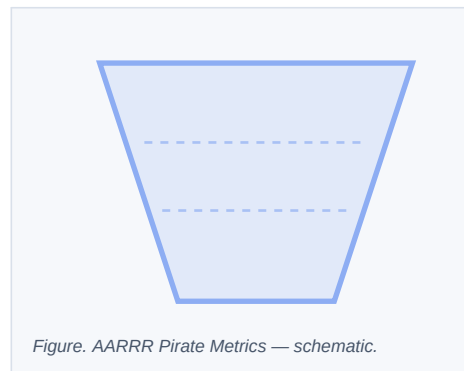
A digital-native funnel — Acquisition, Activation, Retention, Referral, Revenue — suited to platform and SaaS ventures.

WHY IT MATTERS

Digital-native funnel for acquisition, activation, retention, referral and revenue.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Preferable to AIDA for platform and SaaS ventures. Each stage needs a numeric conversion assumption feeding the financial model.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Five stages from acquisition to revenue
- Numeric conversion per stage
- Feeds the financial model directly
- Preferred over AIDA for platforms

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Marketing Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

McClure, D. (2007) Startup metrics for pirates: AARRR! 500 Startups. Available at: <https://www.slideshare.net/dmc500hats> (Accessed: 2 August 2026).

CLV / CAC Ratio

SHEET 34 / 63

Gupta et al. (2006)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

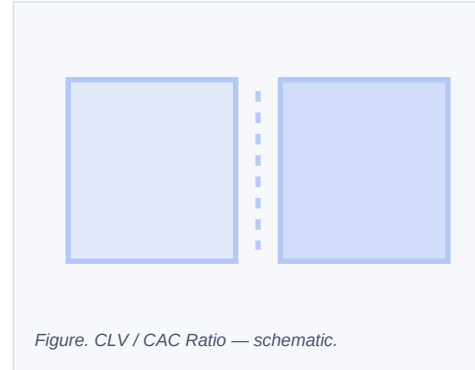
A unit-economics ratio testing customer lifetime value against acquisition cost to prove the acquisition model works.

WHY IT MATTERS

Tests whether the acquisition economics of the plan actually work.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

State the formula, the retention assumption and the discount rate. A ratio below 3:1 requires explicit justification; payback beyond 18 months requires a funding response.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ CLV built from margin and retention

■ CAC built from fully-loaded spend

■ Below 3:1 requires justification

■ Payback beyond 18 months needs a funding response

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Marketing Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Gupta, S., Hanssens, D., Hardie, B., Kahn, W., Kumar, V., Lin, N., Ravishanker, N. and Sriram, S. (2006) 'Modeling customer lifetime value', Journal of Service Research, 9(2), pp. 139–155.

Value-Based Pricing

Nagle & Müller (2018)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

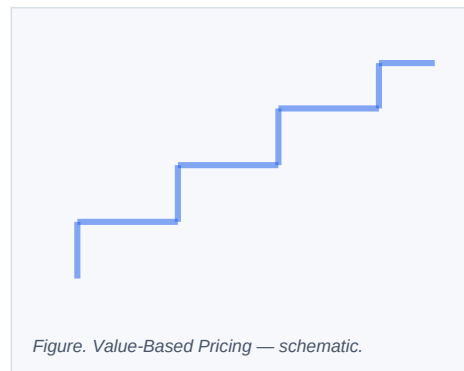
A pricing method that sets price from the customer's economic value rather than from cost-plus guesswork.

WHY IT MATTERS

Justifies price from customer economic value rather than from cost-plus guesswork.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Quantify the reference price and the differentiation value. Cost-plus pricing alone is a weakness under the Marketing Plan criterion.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Establish the reference price
- Quantify the differentiation value
- Price against value delivered
- Cost-plus alone is a rubric weakness

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Marketing Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Nagle, T.T. and Müller, G. (2018) The strategy and tactics of pricing: a guide to growing more profitably. 6th edn. New York: Routledge.

Diffusion of Innovations

SHEET 36 / 63

Rogers (2003)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

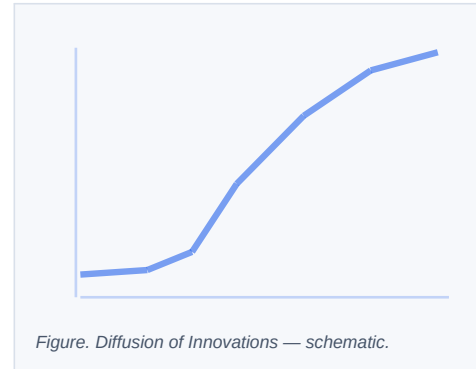
Rogers' adoption model explaining the timing of uptake across adopter categories and justifying the shape of the sales ramp.

WHY IT MATTERS

Explains adoption timing and justifies the shape of the sales ramp.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Identify which adopter category the year-one target represents and show the adoption curve behind the revenue forecast.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Innovators and early adopters first
- Early and late majority follow
- Laggards last
- Year-one target mapped to a category

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Marketing Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Rogers, E.M. (2003) Diffusion of innovations. 5th edn. New York: Free Press.

Value Chain Analysis

SHEET 37 / 63

Porter (1985)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Porter's disaggregation of the firm into primary and support activities to locate where margin is actually created.

WHY IT MATTERS

Separates primary from support activities and locates where margin is created.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Map the venture's own chain, mark the activities kept in house against those outsourced, and state why.



Figure. Value Chain Analysis — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

■ Primary activities create the product

■ Support activities enable them

■ Margin located along the chain

■ In-house vs outsourced decisions justified

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Operations Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Porter, M.E. (1985) Competitive advantage: creating and sustaining superior performance. New York: Free Press.

Service Blueprint

Shostack (1984)

SHEET 38 / 63

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A process map documenting front-stage, back-stage and support activities across the line of visibility for a service.

WHY IT MATTERS

Documents front-stage, back-stage and support processes across the line of visibility.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Essential for service ventures. Shows failure points and the physical evidence at each customer touchpoint.



Figure. Service Blueprint — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Customer actions above the line
- Front-stage and back-stage staff actions
- Support processes below
- Failure points and physical evidence marked

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Operations Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Shostack, G.L. (1984) 'Designing services that deliver', Harvard Business Review, 62(1), pp. 133–139.

Lean Thinking / Waste Elimination

Womack & Jones (2003)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A flow-and-waste discipline that justifies process design and cost assumptions through the five lean principles.

WHY IT MATTERS

Justifies process design and cost assumptions through flow and waste reduction.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Identify value, map the stream, create flow, establish pull, pursue perfection. Quantify at least one waste reduction in the cost model.

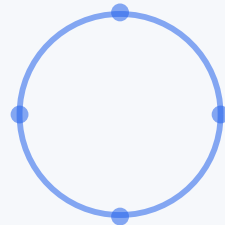


Figure. Lean Thinking / Waste Elimination — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

■ Specify value from the customer's view

■ Map the value stream

■ Create flow and establish pull

■ Pursue perfection — quantify one waste cut

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Operations Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Womack, J.P. and Jones, D.T. (2003) Lean thinking: banish waste and create wealth in your corporation. Rev. edn. London: Simon & Schuster.

Capacity & Bottleneck Planning

Slack et al. (2019)

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PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

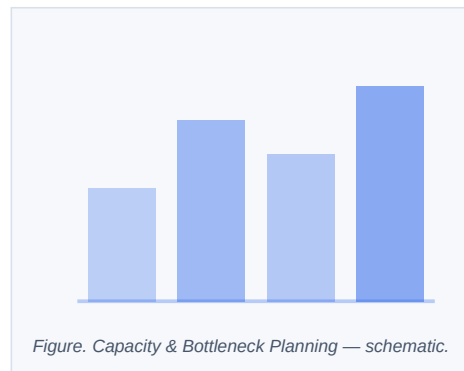
A capacity model proving the operation can deliver the volumes the revenue forecast promises, given its binding bottleneck.

WHY IT MATTERS

Proves the operation can actually deliver the volumes promised in the revenue forecast.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

State design capacity, effective capacity and the binding bottleneck for each forecast year. Capacity must exceed the sales plan or the plan is internally inconsistent.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Design vs effective capacity
- The binding bottleneck named
- Capacity must exceed the sales plan
- Stated per forecast year

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Operations Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Slack, N., Brandon-Jones, A. and Burgess, N. (2019) Operations management. 9th edn. Harlow: Pearson.

SCOR Model

APICS (2017)

SHEET 41 / 63

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The SCOR reference model standardising supply-chain processes — Plan, Source, Make, Deliver, Return and Enable.

WHY IT MATTERS

Standard reference for plan, source, make, deliver, return and enable processes.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Useful where supply chain is material. Map suppliers with full legal form and state lead times and contingency.



Figure. SCOR Model — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Six standard process types
- Applied where supply chain is material
- Suppliers named with legal form
- Lead times and contingency stated

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Operations Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

APICS (2017) Supply chain operations reference model (SCOR) version 12.0. Chicago: APICS.

Quality Management (ISO 9001)

ISO (2015)

SHEET 42 / 63

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The ISO 9001 quality-management standard requiring quality to be described through defined standards, checks and corrective action.

WHY IT MATTERS

Rubric-named requirement: quality management must be described, not asserted.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Define the quality standard, the inspection point, the responsible role and the corrective-action route.

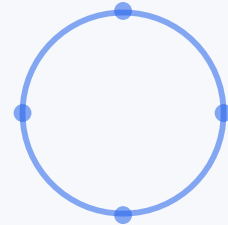


Figure. Quality Management (ISO 9001) — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Quality standard defined
- Inspection point identified
- Responsible role assigned
- Corrective-action route specified

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Operations Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

International Organization for Standardization (2015) ISO 9001:2015 quality management systems — requirements. Geneva: ISO.

Mintzberg's Organisational Configurations

Mintzberg (1979)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Mintzberg's typology of organisational configurations used to justify the chosen structure rather than assert an organigram.

WHY IT MATTERS

Justifies the chosen structure rather than presenting an organigram without argument.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Name the configuration (simple structure, machine bureaucracy, adhocracy) and explain why it suits the venture's stage and environment.

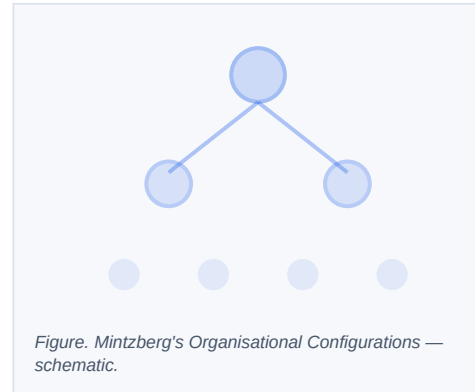


Figure. Mintzberg's Organisational Configurations — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

■ Simple structure, machine bureaucracy, adhocracy...

■ Structure matched to stage and environment

■ Coordination mechanism identified

■ Justified, not merely drawn

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Organization Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Mintzberg, H. (1979) The structuring of organizations. Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice Hall.

RACI Matrix

Slack et al. (2019)

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PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

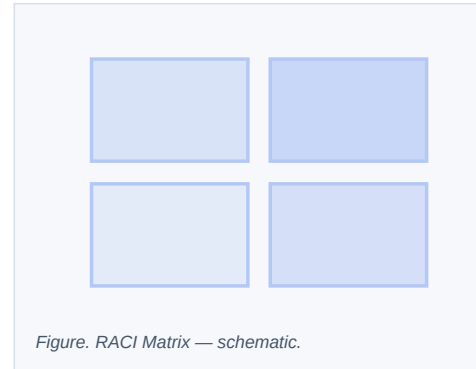
A responsibility matrix removing ambiguity by assigning Responsible, Accountable, Consulted and Informed roles to each activity.

WHY IT MATTERS

Removes ambiguity about who is responsible, accountable, consulted and informed.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Exactly one accountable party per activity. Useful evidence under the Organization Plan criterion.



KEY COMPONENTS

- One accountable party per activity
- Responsible parties may be several
- Consulted and Informed distinguished
- Removes hand-off ambiguity

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Organization Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Slack, N., Brandon-Jones, A. and Burgess, N. (2019) Operations management. 9th edn. Harlow: Pearson.

Belbin Team Roles

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Belbin (2010)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

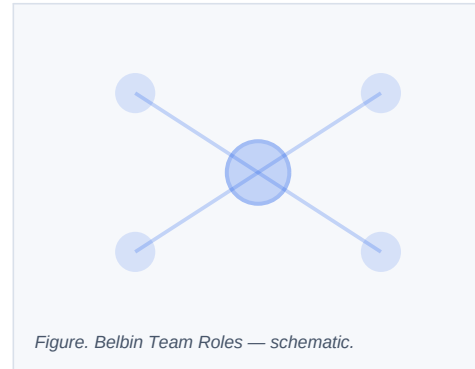
Belbin's nine behavioural team roles, used to evidence that the founding team covers the roles a venture needs.

WHY IT MATTERS

Evidences that the founding team covers the behavioural roles a venture needs.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Map the founding team to roles and name the gaps the first hires are intended to fill.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Nine complementary behavioural roles
- Founding team mapped to roles
- Gaps named explicitly
- First hires fill the gaps

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Organization Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Belbin, R.M. (2010) Team roles at work. 2nd edn. Oxford: Butterworth-Heinemann.

Tuckman Group Development

SHEET 46 / 63

Tuckman (1965)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Tuckman's five-stage model of group development used to frame team-building and onboarding timelines realistically.

WHY IT MATTERS

Frames team-building timelines and onboarding assumptions realistically.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Use to justify the ramp-up period between hiring and full productivity in the HR cost model.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ Forming → Storming → Norming

■ Performing → Adjourning

■ Justifies the ramp to full productivity

■ Feeds the HR cost model

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Organization Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Tuckman, B.W. (1965) 'Developmental sequence in small groups', Psychological Bulletin, 63(6), pp. 384–399.

Schein's Levels of Culture

SHEET 47 / 63

Schein & Schein (2017)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Schein's three levels of culture — artefacts, espoused values and basic assumptions — connecting stated values to lived behaviour.

WHY IT MATTERS

Connects stated core values to artefacts and underlying assumptions.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Show artefacts, espoused values and basic assumptions. Prevents a values section that is purely decorative.



Figure. Schein's Levels of Culture — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Artefacts — the visible surface
- Espoused values — the stated beliefs
- Basic assumptions — the taken-for-granted
- Prevents a decorative values section

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Organization Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Schein, E.H. and Schein, P.A. (2017) Organizational culture and leadership. 5th edn. Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons.

Five-Year P&L, Balance Sheet & Cash Flow

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Brealey et al. (2020)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

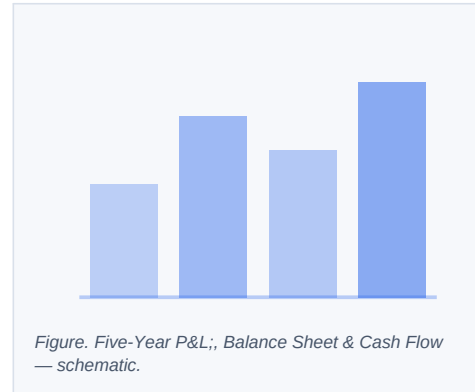
The three compulsory financial statements — profit and loss, balance sheet and cash flow — projected over five years.

WHY IT MATTERS

Compulsory under the EUBS proposal and business plan requirements.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Assets must equal liabilities plus equity in every year. Cash flow must reconcile to the balance sheet cash line. State all assumptions in an appendix.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Assets = liabilities + equity every year
- Cash flow reconciles to the balance sheet
- All assumptions stated in an appendix
- Compulsory under EUBS requirements

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Financial Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Brealey, R.A., Myers, S.C. and Allen, F. (2020) Principles of corporate finance. 13th edn. New York: McGraw-Hill Education.

Break-Even / CVP Analysis

Brealey et al. (2020)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

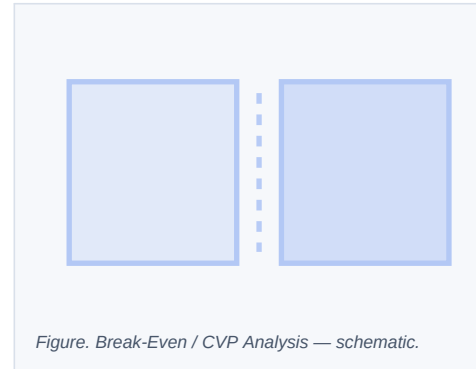
A cost-volume-profit model identifying the sales volume at which the venture stops consuming capital.

WHY IT MATTERS

Identifies the volume at which the venture stops consuming capital.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Separate fixed from variable costs, state the contribution margin, and give break-even in both units and months.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ Fixed and variable costs separated

■ Contribution margin stated

■ Break-even in units and in months

■ The point capital-burn ends

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Financial Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Brealey, R.A., Myers, S.C. and Allen, F. (2020) Principles of corporate finance. 13th edn. New York: McGraw-Hill Education.

NPV, IRR & Payback

Brealey et al. (2020)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

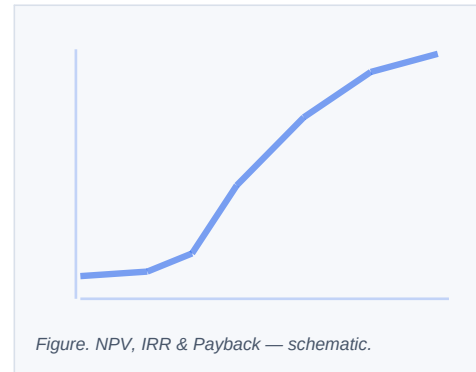
The core investment-appraisal trio — Net Present Value, Internal Rate of Return and payback — testing value creation against the cost of capital.

WHY IT MATTERS

Tests whether the venture creates value against the cost of capital.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

State the discount rate and justify it. Year 0 is the negative investment. A negative NPV is not a failure — an unexplained negative NPV is.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Year 0 is the negative investment
- Discount rate stated and justified
- NPV, IRR and payback reported
- A negative NPV must be explained, not hidden

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Financial Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Brealey, R.A., Myers, S.C. and Allen, F. (2020) Principles of corporate finance. 13th edn. New York: McGraw-Hill Education.

WACC & Capital Structure

Modigliani & Miller (1958)

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PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

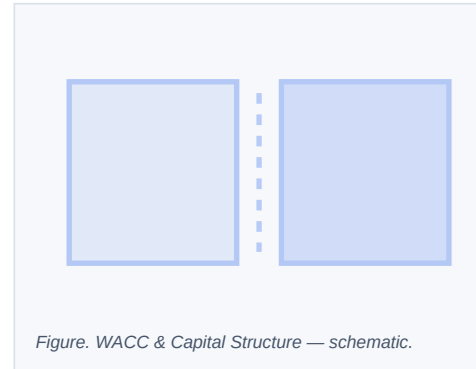
The weighted average cost of capital and capital-structure logic that justifies the discount rate applied in the NPV.

WHY IT MATTERS

Justifies the discount rate applied in the NPV calculation.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Show the cost of equity, the cost of debt, the tax shield and the weights. An unjustified discount rate invalidates the NPV.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Cost of equity and cost of debt
- The tax shield on debt
- Weights by capital source
- An unjustified rate invalidates the NPV

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Financial Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Modigliani, F. and Miller, M.H. (1958) 'The cost of capital, corporation finance and the theory of investment', American Economic Review, 48(3), pp. 261–297.

Sensitivity & Scenario Analysis

SHEET 52 / 63

Brealey et al. (2020)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A robustness test flexing the model's most sensitive variables to present base, best and worst cases and the breaking point.

WHY IT MATTERS

Demonstrates awareness that the forecast is a model, not a prediction.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Flex the two variables the model is most sensitive to, present base, best and worst cases, and state the breaking point.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Identify the two most sensitive variables
- Flex them across a defensible range
- Base, best and worst cases
- State the breaking point

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Financial Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Brealey, R.A., Myers, S.C. and Allen, F. (2020) Principles of corporate finance. 13th edn. New York: McGraw-Hill Education.

Legal Form & Statutory Reserve

GmbHG § 5a (2024)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The German legal-form and statutory-reserve rules requiring the venture and every named competitor to state their legal form precisely.

WHY IT MATTERS

Rubric-named legal and taxation component; German ventures must state the form precisely.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Identify the venture and every named competitor with full legal form on first mention. The 25% statutory reserve obligation applies to the UG, not the GmbH.



Figure. Legal Form & Statutory Reserve — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Venture and rivals named with legal form
- GmbH vs UG distinction observed
- 25% statutory reserve applies to the UG
- A rubric-named legal component

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Financial Plan

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Bundesministerium der Justiz (2024) Gesetz betreffend die Gesellschaften mit beschränkter Haftung (GmbHG), § 5a. Berlin: Bundesamt für Justiz.

Toulmin Model of Argument

Toulmin (2003)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

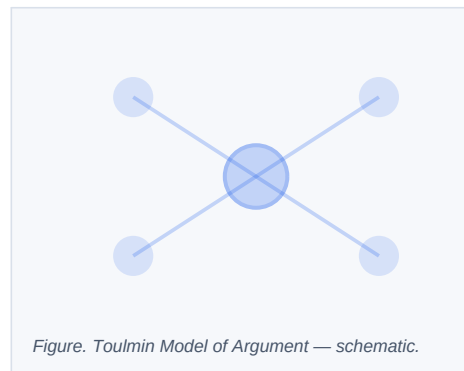
Toulmin's model of argument separating claim, ground, warrant, backing and qualifier — the diagnostic for Analytical Thinking.

WHY IT MATTERS

Diagnostic for the Analytical Thinking criterion: separates claim, ground, warrant and qualifier.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Any load-bearing claim needs data and a stated warrant linking the two. Most rubric losses under Analytical Thinking are missing warrants.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Claim — the assertion made
- Ground — the data behind it
- Warrant — the link between them
- Most rubric losses are missing warrants

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Analytical Thinking

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Toulmin, S.E. (2003) The uses of argument. Updated edn. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

The Logical Chain

EU Business School (2026)

PART II · BUSINESS PLAN

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

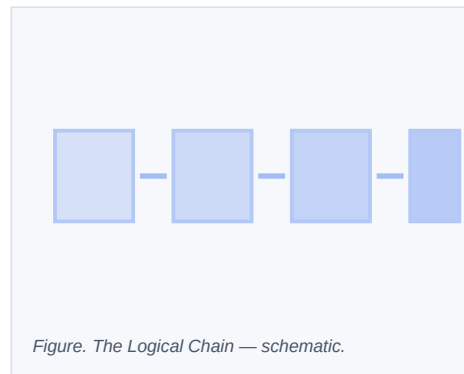
The EUBS logical chain — PESTEL → Competitors → SWOT → TOWS → Strategy → Mix → Operations → Financials — the strongest predictor of a high Analytical Thinking mark.

WHY IT MATTERS

The single strongest predictor of a high Analytical Thinking mark at EUBS.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

PESTEL → Competitors → SWOT → TOWS → Strategy → Marketing Mix → Operations → Financials. Every downstream decision must be traceable to an upstream finding.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Each stage feeds the next
- Every downstream decision traces upstream
- No free-standing assertions
- The spine of the whole plan

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part II · Business Plan · Analytical Thinking

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

EU Business School (2026) Master programme capstone guidelines AY2025–2026. Munich: EU Business School.

Thumbnail Thinking

Meier (2025)

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PART III · DEFENSE

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

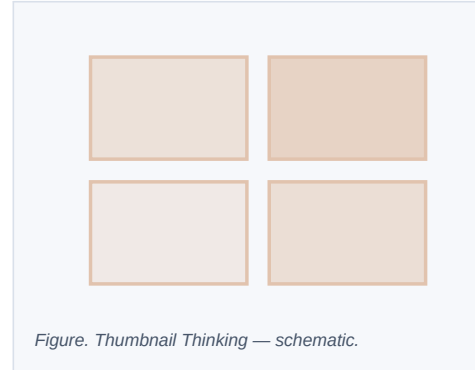
J.D. Meier's method of sketching the whole deck as small hand-drawn frames before any slide software is opened.

WHY IT MATTERS

Sketch the whole deck as small frames before any slide software is opened, so structure is fixed before decoration begins.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

One idea per thumbnail, drawn by hand at postcard size. If the idea does not fit the frame, it is two ideas. Sequence the thumbnails on a wall and cut ruthlessly before building.



KEY COMPONENTS

- One idea per thumbnail
- Drawn by hand at postcard size
- Sequenced on a wall
- Cut ruthlessly before building

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part III · Defense · Storyboarding

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Meier, J.D. (2025) Thumbnail thinking: sketch your way to clarity. Available at: <https://jdmeier.com> (Accessed: 2 August 2026).

Message Strategy — one clear message

Bostelaar (2016, 2023)

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

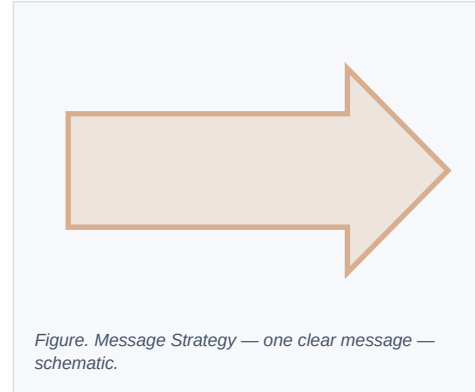
Kurt Bostelaar's message-strategy discipline that fixes one governing message and makes every slide serve it.

WHY IT MATTERS

Fixes a single governing message and makes every subsequent slide serve it; complex ideas made simple, visual and practical.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Write the one sentence the jury should repeat afterwards. Then test every thumbnail: does it advance that sentence? If not, it is deleted or moved to the appendix.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Write the one sentence the jury repeats
- Test every thumbnail against it
- Advance the message or cut the slide
- Complex ideas made simple and visual

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part III · Defense · Message Strategy

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Bostelaar, K. (2023) Making the complex simple, visual and practical: a message design approach. Leverlo. Available at: <https://www.leverlo.com> (Accessed: 2 August 2026).

Assertion–Evidence Structure

Alley (2013)

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PART III · DEFENSE

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Alley's slide structure replacing topic headlines and bullet lists with a full-sentence assertion supported by a visual.

WHY IT MATTERS

Replaces topic headlines and bullet lists with a full-sentence assertion supported by a visual.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Headline is a complete sentence stating the message. Body is a chart, image or diagram — not text. This directly serves the Visuals criterion of the defense rubric.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Headline is a complete sentence
- Body is a chart or image, not text
- Directly serves the Visuals criterion
- One assertion per slide

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part III · Defense · Slide Design

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Alley, M. (2013) The craft of scientific presentations: critical steps to succeed and critical errors to avoid. 2nd edn. New York: Springer.

Sparkline / What Is — What Could Be

Duarte (2010)

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PART III · DEFENSE

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

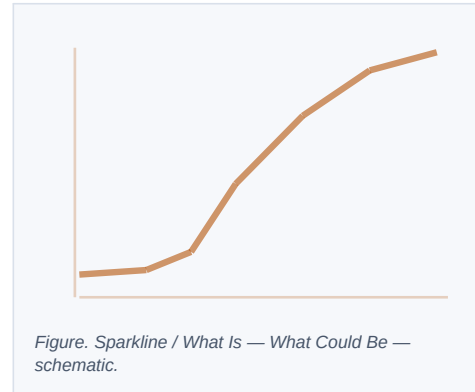
Duarte's narrative pattern alternating between what is and what could be to build tension toward a call to action.

WHY IT MATTERS

Builds narrative tension by alternating between the current reality and the proposed future.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Open with the problem as it stands, move to the venture's future state, and close with a call to action. Suits the problem–solution arc of a business plan defense.



KEY COMPONENTS

- Open with the problem as it stands
- Move to the proposed future state
- Alternate to build tension
- Close on a call to action

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part III · Defense · Narrative

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Duarte, N. (2010) Resonate: present visual stories that transform audiences. Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons.

Pyramid Principle for Speaking

Minto (2009)

SHEET 60 / 63

PART III · DEFENSE

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Minto's pyramid applied to speaking: answer-first delivery so the jury knows the conclusion within ninety seconds.

WHY IT MATTERS

Answer-first delivery so the jury knows the conclusion within the first ninety seconds.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

State the governing thought, then the supporting arguments in descending order of strength. Never build to a reveal in an academic defense.

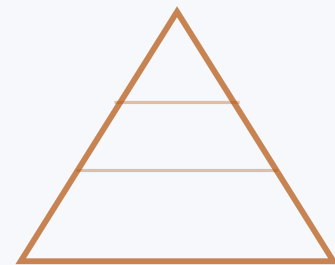


Figure. Pyramid Principle for Speaking — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Governing thought stated first
- Supporting arguments in descending strength
- No building to a reveal
- Conclusion in the first ninety seconds

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part III · Defense · Narrative

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Minto, B. (2009) The pyramid principle: logic in writing and thinking. 3rd edn. Harlow: Financial Times Prentice Hall.

Multimedia & Cognitive Load Principles

Mayer (2009)

SHEET 61 / 63

PART III · DEFENSE

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Mayer's evidence-based multimedia principles explaining why dense slides reduce comprehension.

WHY IT MATTERS

Evidence base for why dense slides reduce comprehension.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Apply the coherence, signalling and redundancy principles: remove decoration, cue the key element, and never read the slide aloud verbatim.



KEY COMPONENTS

■ Coherence — remove decoration

■ Signalling — cue the key element

■ Redundancy — never read slides verbatim

■ Grounded in cognitive-load research

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part III · Defense · Slide Design

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Mayer, R.E. (2009) Multimedia learning. 2nd edn. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Question Anticipation Matrix

EU Business School (2026)

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PART III · DEFENSE

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

An anticipation matrix listing likely jury challenges with prepared thirty-second answers and backup slides — worth 30% of the defense mark.

WHY IT MATTERS

Quality of responses to questions carries 30% of the defense mark — the highest single weight.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

List the ten most likely challenges, write a thirty-second answer for each, and prepare one appendix slide per answer. Rehearse retrieving them by number.

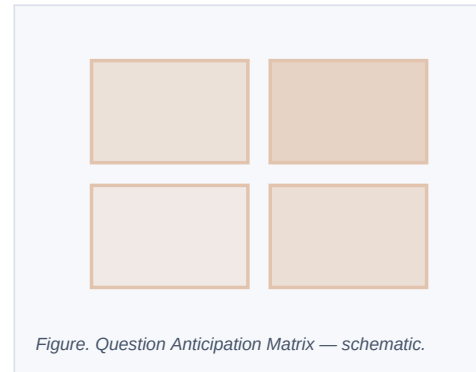


Figure. Question Anticipation Matrix — schematic.

KEY COMPONENTS

- Ten most likely challenges listed
- A thirty-second answer for each
- One appendix slide per answer
- Rehearsed by retrieval number

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part III · Defense · Q&A;

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

EU Business School (2026) Business plan and final project oral defense guidelines. Munich: EU Business School.

EUBS Defense Slide Requirements

EU Business School (2026)

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PART III · DEFENSE

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

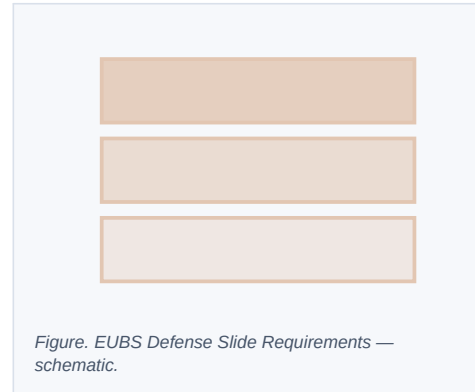
The EUBS defense-slide compliance rules: one slide per capstone section and a graded, matching reference list.

WHY IT MATTERS

One slide per capstone section is mandatory, and the reference list is a graded component.

HOW TO APPLY IT CORRECTLY

Fifteen to twenty minutes total, leaving time for jury questions. The reference list slide is mandatory and must correspond to the in-text citations used.



KEY COMPONENTS

- One slide per capstone section
- Fifteen to twenty minutes total
- A mandatory reference-list slide
- Citations must match the in-text list

WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE CAPSTONE Part III · Defense · Compliance

SOURCE (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

EU Business School (2026) Business plan and final project oral defense guidelines. Munich: EU Business School.